

We All Have a Heart

I crouched in the darkness, doing my best to steady my breathing. The rocks were wet and sharp, this deep in the cave I could smell the salt from the waves that had broken down the cliff face.

Some light and decorations would make this a pretty cool teen hangout, a fun and spooky place to make childhood memories.

The swish of its dress stopped that from being a possibility.

The townspeople clammed up when asked to talk about it, as if avoiding the facts actually prevented the grisly deaths.

Pretty sure it was the opposite.

I'd managed to get the old barman drunk enough to get a name.

'The Stalker.'

Bit stereotypical, let alone not giving much distinguishing features. But maybe it's what looms in the darkness, what makes your imagination squirm, that breeds the fear.

Despite my confidence I could feel my own trepidation. I was alone, near a dangerous creature.

I could hear the scrapes it made on the rocks, the heavy, choking breaths it sucked into its maw.

But like any any animal, everything has a routine. Swish, swish, back and forth, I timed its every movement.

One.

Two.

Now.

I scurried through the darkness, illuminating the ground with my phone's flashlight, heart in my mouth as I waited for the shriek that would give the game away.

Turning the corner, I dutifully avoided the long, thorny black vines that twisted and curled on the ground and roof, all leading towards my goal.

There.

A pink, slimy heart was beating inside a cocoon of those barbed vines. It had its own light, the pink shining away the darkness.

Sliding out a knife I began slicing through the heart's prison.

As soon as I made the first cut I heard its scream.

Now I had the Stalker's attention.

With speed I cut back and forth, hissing in pain when a thorn sliced deep into my index finger.

One more slash and I would free the prize, just one more ...

A black hand grabbed my face, crushing my nose and covering one eye socket. Immediately I felt my face begin burning, my screams muffled by a huge palm, squeezing with all its might.

Yet with one good eye directing, I managed to cut the final vine and grab the heart. I raised my arm in a throw and felt the immense pressure on my face relinquish.

"Puuuuttt ... itttt ... backkkk ..."

I began squeezing the heart in response. The hand let me go and I barely managed to stay upright, taking a step forward before turning around.

In front of me was an eight foot tall woman, covered in black cloth from head to toe. Dozens of the vines pierced all parts of her body. Yet their jet black colour and the Stalkers' dress was quickly fading grey.

I barely noticed, too busy raising a finger to the agonising wounds on my face, I touched something soft and bubbly.

I think it used to be my cheek.

"Pllleeeaaassee ..."

Its voice was like a serpent, slithering into my skull.

I walked past it.

It tried to swat me, but it couldn't move, it was turning to stone, the edges of its body already hard.

"Whyyyyyy..." It managed to stammer out.

"Don't worry, you will live again soon.

Just ... through someone else. This towns drying up. I've got much juicer ground for you this coming century."

I left it whining there.

Our family did a lot for the Stalker. Why was I the one who got their face burned off?